VR251 Aesthetics

Jiva Amalia

Chongdan Pan

516370910121

Take Home Exam

I understand what plagiarism is and I hereby attest that this is my own work, that I completed it independently, and that I did not plagiarize any part of this exam.

1. Part I China's Van Goghs

The film *China's Van Goghs* tells a story about how art changes a person. The main character, Xiaoyong Zhao, has been imitating Van Gogh's artistic work for 20 years. Although Xiaoyong had drawn and observed a lot mechanical and manual reproduction, he didn't have a reflection and change his attitude to art until he saw the original artworks through his own eyes. At first glance, all these paintings look quite similar and should be considered as art according to three art theories we've learned [1], but only Van Goghs' can change Xiaoyong's mind. Therefore, I'd argue the value of art lies in how deep and distinct interaction the artwork can make.

There is no doubt that Xiaoyong's imitation has a high quality, because he said "I almost enter your world now!" to Van Gogh in his dream. However, it seems they never be considered as a masterpiece because they're sold at a store at a lower price rather than collected at a museum. Therefore, I think Plato would rethink about the difference between art and imitation after watching the film. The imitation work mainly serves for a decorative purpose. For an owner, of course he can stare at it and think about its story.

However, such interaction is common and superficial, because it can be easily obtained from other imitations. One may argue that an imitation can also serve as a substitute of an original work, so that he can have interaction similar to those from the original work without going to a museum. This phenomenon illustrates the negative and positive effect caused by reproduction and the destruction of aura discussed by Walter Benjamin [2]. However, the similar interaction is still based on the work in the museum, so in essence, it's not with the imitation but the original work. Therefore, the imitation only broadens the original work's interaction from museum, rather than destroy its authenticity.

For an artwork with high aesthetical value, its interaction depends on the synthesis of all properties, including its history, skills, creators, etc. Hence, the interaction must be distinct and can't be duplicated by other works. For example, the superficial color and textures are the bases of Van Gogh's painting. Its higher value lies in stimulate viewers to imagine Van Gogh's mind and status when he drew them. Van Gogh's master hand and artistic skill is the way for him to express them. The first part is common, the third part can only be done through an excellent craftsman, but the second is unique and what make the painting a masterpiece, and it can't come from imitation. It's noticeable that even normal people can create artwork as long as it can have deep and distinct interaction. For example, one imitation artwork from Xiaoyong may hardly be considered as an artwork, but what if they're all put together? The combination uses a very simple artistic skill, but it let viewers think about the career of an imitator. There is no doubt it can achieve a higher aesthetic value.

Since an artwork's value depends on the depth of interaction it can make, it keeps changing because interaction changes according to interactor. I always wonder whether Van Gogh's painting will still be considered as art after thousands of years when its color fades out a lot or completely becomes black. At that time, people may focus more on a painting's status in human history and more like one preserved better. What if it's kept well but human evolve so much that they don't use eyes to see something through light and color? It won't be an art because its interaction with human is lost, even though the painting remains same. Usually, the deeper an interaction is, the longer it lasts. Our preserving Van Gogh's painting in a museum proves that we all believe it can have a longer and interaction on human.

In conclusion, it is interaction that defines an art Creation makes an artwork able to make deep and distinct interaction with viewers, which gives it a soul and a higher aesthetic value. In this film, Van Gogh's artworks have such a deep interaction that starts emotionally, and ends rationally. The emotional part is Xiaoyong's depression and confusion after he saw the original work at the museum while the rational part is his reflection and realization on creation. Similarly, for the film itself, it's so impressive because it let us generate a deep understanding about China Van Gogh.

2. Part II Wrapped Coast and Surrounded Islands

In Christo projects, he decorated or changed the view of nature scene through great efforts. His works were created both naturally and artificially, and they actually blurred the line between nature-objects and art-objects, challenging Hepburn's claim that "there are certain important differences between natural-objects and art-objects" [3].

There is even no clear boundary between “detachment” and “involvement” in Christo’s project, since there is no doubt such project is completed by “using and manipulating nature” but human still can both be actor and spectator in the scene and interact with it. This color and shape of fabric and materials over the coast and islands gives us determinateness of art-objects, but we can’t imagine their specific shape under blowing wind, hence the restlessness and alertness are kept as well.

Christo’s projects prove that natural-objects and art-objects can be unified organically so that they bring us more impressive aesthetic experience than they’re alone. According to Hepburn, “pursuit of natural beauty is challenge risking drawing a blank and gaining nothing”, but it’s more extreme in Christo’s case. It’s still hard for me to imagine how Christo mobilize resource to complete so controversial and large-scale projects even after watching the videos. For Christo, he must also be stressful and unsure what effects these projects will achieve and whether they’ll succeed at such a high cost. Actually, such cost and Christo artificial work enhance the features of natural beauty discussed by Hepburn, which is the uncertainty. Hepburn also considered motion and expands as great feature of natural objects. In Cristo’s projects, the sand beach, steep cliff, and sea around islands disappeared and became fabric blowing in the wind. The fabric is still in movement, but it connected subtle movement of small natural-objects and presented them together in a uniform, direct and dramatic way.

Cristo projects have difference in many details, including its theme, locations, and skills, etc. But they share the similar idea and effect generally, which is using artist’s skill and mind to modify and strength the natural beauty. When we apply Hepburn’s

idea to his work, the line between natural-object and art-objects disappears, but Hepburn's analysis about the features about nature beauty remains, and it's even more obvious and stronger because of the addition of artistic work.

3. Part III Option I Hume and Kant and AI Music

The music is quite pleasing and probably accepted by people with good taste, which is same for Kant, who would regard music from AIVA as beautiful. The basis for AIVA's creation is a huge amount of music and analysis of what feeling it brings to listeners. Therefore, AIVA's principle conform Kant's opinion where good taste requires previous empirically judgements and reference to precedents" [4]. All AIVA's action is performed through logic and data, but it can create music that many specialists can't. The excellent performance challenges Kant opinion about the importance of logic for taste. Even though taste should be subsumptive, logic seems to play a distinct and nonnegligible role.

On the contrary, Hume would probably dislike it because AIVA only satisfies partial condition for a good taste. Superficially, AIVA's process for analysis and creation is similar to making comparison and being "free from all prejudice", which is also important to be a good critic for Hume [5]. However, this is also all AIVA has to create music and hence it lacks imagination, clear conception, and liveness necessary for high taste. After all, AIVA only can imagine through random guess and put them into pattern from previous analysis result. But AIVA's success also brings challenge to Hume because it seems one can have a good taste as long as he or she can analyze and

compares artwork in a specific way. The abundance of comparison can make up the loss of imagination and understanding.

To sum up, AIVA's music both partially satisfies and challenges Kant and Hume's opinion. But Kant's is subsumptive while Hume's requires more, hence it probably leaves Kant a better impression.

4. Part IV Is this Art?

I'd regard *the banana on the wall* with its certificate together as art. We can apply the formalism theory because it's designed primarily to exhibit Cattelan's unique significant art form. According to Cattelan's previous work, like the gold toilet, the significant art form is his way to create absurdity from ordinary concept. In this case, such absurdity lies in the price at which the banana is sold, hence the certificate is essential to make it an artwork. The limitation for the formalism is its omission for the content objects without forms, but the banana has artistic content as well. Another limitation of the theory its arguments' premises, but the banana also has an artistic purpose and the its form is clearly an important property. Since the banana on the wall is not bounded by the limitation of formalism, it can be regarded as art.

Reference

1. Carrol, N. (1999). Philosophy of Art: A contemporary Introduction. London. Routledge.
2. Benjamin, W. (1969) The Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction. Illuminations. New York.
3. Hepburn, R.W. (1966) Contemporary Aesthetic and the Neglect of Natural Beauty. British Analytical Philosophy. London.
4. Kant, I. (1790) The Critique of Judgement. Hackett Publishing Company. Indianapolis. Cambridge.
5. Hume, D. (2006) The Standard of Taste.

Criteria for Evaluation:	Excellent	Very Good	Good	Needs v
Argumentation • Strength and soundness of thesis complete with claim, evidence, and result • Clarity of map of the essay in introduction and evidence of transitions • Clarity of argument, structure of argument development, fulfillment of thesis promise • Clarity of transitions showing the connection between argument points, between claim and evidence, between evidence and illustration, and between paragraphs overall • Anticipation of counterarguments		√		
Relevance • Connection between essay answer and prompt • Connection between essay answer and class readings • Connection between evidence and argument	√			
Use of Sources • Understanding and explanation of sources • Relevance of sources to argument • Application of sources to argument and case studies • Proper signaling and documentation of sources • Care to be **Free of Plagiarism**		√		
Originality • Depth of Argumentation • Ability to interpret, interrogate, and push beyond rather than simply repeat what the readings say • Ability to allow readings and case studies to expand rather than limit interpretation and analysis • Ability to avoid matching or labeling and instead discover new aspects or hidden aspects of both theories and art works		√		

Criteria for Evaluation:	Excellent	Very Good	Good	Needs v
Clarity • Consistency of language level and formality • Explanation of Terms • Specificity of Statements • Connection/transition between sentences and paragraphs		√		
Lack of BS • Absence of made-up statements • Absence of irrelevant, vague, general, unproven, stereotypical statements • Absence of 'common sense 'statements not grounded in evidence • Absence of careless, misleading, or false statements		√		